



Niyam Bhushan

Dud Books

e-Books: Damned If I Love Them, Damned If I Don't

How could something so right go so wrong? At first glance, the concept of an electronic book, or e-book, is brilliant. Save millions of trees and the environment. Save bookshelf space, or even free up the dedicated library room in your home. Carry thousands of books electronically on a single device. Look up any word or phrase in an instant, from across your entire collection. Out-of-print books can live virtually forever. Lend out e-books by spawning multiple copies. Read books in the dark. Plug in fancy new technologies for a host of features and conveniences that are as yet unimaginable. But... should you trust a book that has no spine?

Read me if you can

A book is a book. You just open and read it. But here's how things go horribly wrong with an e-book. Which expensive device would you choose? Should you purchase a dedicated device from among a dozen different types, chief among them the Amazon Kindle, the Nook from Barnes & Noble, or the Sony Reader? How about reading e-books on your smartphone? Or do you fancy a laptop, a netbook or the funnily-named iPad; maybe even your games console?

Assuming you get over this first hurdle, which digital file format would you prefer? At last count, I discovered 18 competing file formats. Here's a comparison of them on Wikipedia: <http://bit.ly/eBookFormats>. Interestingly, PDF is so popular that even Apple's just-launched iPad has immediately upgraded its iBook software to support it. That's capricious. PDF is a 'container' file format, a catch-all black plastic bag, into which you can throw pretty much any file format. That also includes the Flash file format, and we've already seen Steve Jobs, the Zeus, hurl his thunderbolt at that. So file formats you blindly trust may also break, or have disabled features, on different platforms.

Okay-dokey, let's behave like intelligent people: pick one of the more popular file formats, invest money in building a formidable collection of e-books, and then pray that the file format and the hardware never get obsolete. After all, trust is a good thing, especially when it comes to trusting money-minded corporations, who always know when it is a good time to make you re-invest in new formats for the same content. I've got books, which are family heirlooms for the same grandfather read almost a century ago. I don't think my son

will be able, technically and legally, to share his expensive e-books with his own younger sister, within just five years.

You're an open book

Make yourself comfortable. Curl up with pillows and quilts and your favourite book in quiet privacy. I hope you're equally comfortable about hidden eyes watching and logging every page you read, and all your reading preferences and habits. Read the EFF's guide to e-book privacy here: <http://bit.ly/eBookPrivacy>. Did you think that how you read your book on the device you own was your own business? Think again. Maybe the e-book is not even digitally in your control. Your e-books may just as well be perched somewhere on a

Web-cloud, merely streamed or cached to your device while you're reading. You may as well find your collection of e-books from different vendors stored on separate clouds, locked in to specific devices, and

not allowing you to consolidate all in one place.

This total mess is bigger than the one that the Linux and FOSS community battles in the world of *mukt* and *mukt* software, and open standards. With literacy such a high mandate for economic growth, e-books can also solve a lot of challenges in education. Yet just imagine how much bigger the mess will become, when schools and students are pushed into adopting a culture of reading e-books. Classrooms and libraries will turn into marketing battlefields.

Fortunately, the Linux and FOSS community understands the core values required to usher in a better world for e-books, with *mukt* and *mukt* software, Creative Commons licences, open standards, and a tough anti-DRM approach. We just need to turn our attention to this e-book challenge, at all FOSS events, on mailing lists and forums. Meanwhile, I'm curling up in bed with the smell of real ink in my nostrils—from the pages of the 'Geet Govindam' by Jayadev. Just the right book with which to welcome the sudden boom of thunder and the monsoon, across our sub-continent. **END**

About Niyam

Inspired by the vision of Osho. Copyright June 2010: Niyam Bhushan. freedomyugs@gmail.com. First published in LinuxForYou magazine. Verbatim copying, publishing and distribution of this article is encouraged in any language and medium, so long as this copyright notice is preserved. In Hindi, 'mukt' means 'free-of-cost', and 'mukt' means 'with freedom.'